Not the Keys of a Piano

A three-minute dialogue on Notes from Underground

Scott and Claude

Oct 27, 2026

Contents

Two readers: ***Avery*** *and* ***Riley****. About 430 words, roughly three minutes read aloud. Links are to time marks in Larry Cedar's performance of the Garnett translation.*

AVERY: "I am a sick man. I am a spiteful man." That's how Dostoevsky's *Notes from Underground* begins. 1:30

RILEY: Not exactly a warm welcome.

AVERY: He doesn't want one. He's a retired clerk who has spent forty years in his corner, and he tells us that to be too conscious is an illness. 6:40

RILEY: An illness? Most of us think knowing ourselves is the cure.

AVERY: Not for him. He sees through every motive, including his own, so he can't become anything. Not spiteful, not kind, not a hero, not even an insect.

RILEY: So what's he arguing against?

AVERY: The confident people who say we only do nasty things because we don't know our own interests. Show us our real advantage, they say, and we'll be good out of sheer necessity. 13:41

RILEY: That sounds reasonable.

AVERY: That's exactly his target. He says what a person wants is simply independent choice, whatever that independence may cost and wherever it may lead. 15:11

RILEY: Even if the choice is stupid?

AVERY: Especially then. A man may choose something stupid just to keep the right to choose it. Otherwise, he says, we'd be nothing but the keys of a piano. 18:29

RILEY: Press the key, and the note sounds.

AVERY: And he asks the reformers a question: how do you know it's even desirable to reform people that way? 19:03

RILEY: But he's hardly a hero of freedom.

AVERY: No, and the second half shows it. He meets Liza, a young woman in a brothel, and gives her a moving speech about the life she could still have. He gives her his address.

RILEY: And she comes.

AVERY: She does. And he turns on her. He tells her it was all a game, that power was what he wanted. 1:21:13 Then he breaks down and says, "I can't be good." 1:24:03

RILEY: So he can stand up to the reformers, but he can't accept one person's kindness.

AVERY: He even admits that, for him, loving meant showing his moral superiority. 1:25:04

RILEY: And how does he leave us?

AVERY: He turns the mirror on us. Give any one of us a little more independence, he says, relax the control, and we'd be begging to be under control again at once. 1:29:45

RILEY: That's chilling.

AVERY: It's why this is a good place to start thinking about defiance and control. He sees the danger of being managed for our own good. But he also suspects we might want it.

RILEY: Then the question is whether we can choose freely without ending up alone in his corner.

AVERY: Or whether we'd even notice we'd stopped choosing.